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THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON



6350

MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telephone Call from Prime Minister Thatcher
of the United Kingdom (U)

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Margaret Thatcher, Prime Minister
Robert Hutchings, NSC Staff (Notetaker)

DATE, TIME August 9, 1990, 10:02 - 10:16 a.m.
AND PLACE: The Oval Office

Prime Minister Thatcher initiated the call. (U)

The President: Margaret, how are you? (U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: Fine, and you? (U)

The President: Fine. I was so pleased with your announcement.
Things appear to be in very good shape. (U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: I agree. What I want to say is
congratulations on your operation. I saw your broadcast on
television. It was marvelous. It is getting very good press in
the UK. (U)

The President: Aren't you intrigued by the Arab League Summit
today? I hope Mubarak gets the votes necessary to get the other
Arab states involved. (U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: (b) (1)
(b) (1)

The President: (b) (1)
(b) (1)

Prime Minister Thatcher: (b) (1)
(b) (1)

The President: Maybe he will come around. I've been very
pleased with Ozal. (U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: Yes. Congratulations. He has been
marvelous. (U)

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The President: Your visit here really helped. It gave the whole situation an ecumenical look. (U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: No one can be alone on this. | (b)(1)
(b)(1)

Then my Tornados will go where your ships are in Dharan. I am also sending three minesweepers. They will be ready by Monday. Our people are coming over tomorrow to discuss the complicated issue of rules of engagement. (Ø)

The President: It is very important. Will they be going to DoD? (Ø)

Prime Minister Thatcher: Yes. In our last operation, we didn't have to think about confronting these enormous tankers, about what to do if they don't stop. (Ø)

The President: We were talking this morning about getting on with the interdiction problem. The Pentagon is working on it. I had a long talk with Qaboos yesterday. He was very forthcoming. He said he would deliver anything we need. I suspect your talks with him will also go well. (Ø)

(b)(1)

The President: I agree. (The President asks Brent Scowcroft whether we have an answer yet.) We have not gotten a definitive answer but we will try to get one. (Ø)

(b)(1)

The President: Good. Let me pass this along and make sure we are on the same wavelength. (U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: Another worry is chemical weapons. I thought you gave a good, strong warning to Iraq. (Ø)

The President: Yes, though I left it vague. But the man is irrational. Fortunately, some of our men have experience operating in great heat with this heavy protective clothing. (Ø)

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Prime Minister Thatcher:

(b) (1)

(b) (1)

The President: We need that. The press is already asking where the Arabs are. King Hassan was very forthcoming. (Ø)

Prime Minister Thatcher: Yes. He is enormously courageous. (U)

(b) (1)

Prime Minister Thatcher: It won't be long. The action you took so quickly achieved the first objective, of stopping the Iraqis from moving farther south, brilliantly. (Ø)

The President: I agree. They are digging in, but there are no signs of moving down. One other thing: I have two reports of enormous brutality in Kuwait, one from a member of the royal family and another from one of the Sheiks. What they described was brutal, ugly. If your people have any contacts there and can get this word out, it would help our cause. They have also broken into the vaults in Kuwait and taken the gold out. If you can confirm these reports, it might be good to make them public. (Ø)

Prime Minister Thatcher: Our press this morning reported that a British Air stewardess was raped by an Iraqi soldier, so we can confirm this brutality. We made a demarche to the Iraqis and were told the man had been shot, but they seem to be glorying in brutality. (Ø)

The President: If we could get the word out, it would solidify world opinion. Thanks for your leadership. (U)

Prime Minister Thatcher: It was your leadership. I was just a chum. (U)

-- End of Conversation --

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